

From Monument to Ruin:
Interpreting Moses Ezekiel's Confederate
Memorial in Arlington

In Arlington National Cemetery, a bronze woman once stood atop a thirty-two-foot pedestal, her head crowned with olive leaves and her arms outstretched in solemn grace. The figure faced southward, toward the old Confederacy, and in one hand she raised a laurel wreath—the classical emblem of victory—while the other held a plow stock. Around her, thirty-two sculpted figures circled the base: soldiers and civilians, angels and allegories, even two enslaved people whose calm faces suggested loyalty rather than bondage. Cast in bronze and mounted on rough granite, the work shimmered with dignity under the Washington sun. From a distance, it appeared serene and unifying; up close, its inscriptions and imagery told a different story. This was Moses Jacob Ezekiel's *Confederate Memorial* (1914), commissioned by the United Daughters of the Confederacy (UDC) and dismantled by the U.S. Army in 2023 after more than a century in place.

Cultural geographer J. B. Jackson once wrote that “monuments are not history itself; they are interpretations of history.”¹ They materialize what societies choose to remember—and what they prefer to forget. Jackson observed that many monuments commemorate an imagined “golden age,” their symbolism vague enough to transform myth into collective memory.² Ezekiel's *Confederate Memorial* embodies precisely that process. Rather than recording the Civil War's historical truth, it interprets the Confederacy through allegory, translating loss into moral triumph and slavery into paternal devotion. To view the monument through Jackson's lens is to see how the Lost Cause ideology was not only narrated in speeches and textbooks but also cast into bronze.

¹ John Brinckerhoff Jackson, *The Necessity for Ruins and Other Topics* (Massachusetts: University of Massachusetts Press, 1980), 50.

² Jackson, *Necessity for Ruins*, 52-54.

By 1914, nearly fifty years after Appomattox, the UDC sought to reframe the Civil War as a chivalric struggle for regional honor. They turned to Ezekiel—a respected sculptor living in Rome and himself a former Confederate cadet—to give their mythology form. The resulting memorial was a grand synthesis of classical composition and political revisionism. Its central female figure, draped in flowing robes reminiscent of ancient goddesses, personified the South as noble, pure, and reconciled. Beneath her feet, a biblical inscription proclaimed, “They have beat their swords into ploughshares,” while the Latin motto “*Victrix causa diis placuit sed victa Catoni*” (“The victorious cause pleased the gods, but the lost cause pleased Cato”) translated defeat into virtue³

The frieze around the base transformed Confederate society into a tableau of harmony. Soldiers march confidently to war, women pray in stoic patience, and two enslaved figures—a “mammy” holding a white infant and a man following his master—embody the myth of willing servitude. As Arlington National Cemetery has since acknowledged, the monument offers “highly sanitized depictions of slavery.”⁴ These sculpted bodies, frozen in fidelity, turn subjugation into loyalty and violence into tenderness. The very smoothness of the bronze surface erases the rough texture of history; the monument’s aesthetic beauty conceals its ideological violence. In this sense, Ezekiel’s work performs exactly what Jackson warned of: it transforms history into an idealized scene detached from moral consequence. Its classical language—robes, laurel, Latin—suggests timeless heroism rather than treason. The result is not remembrance but reverence.

³ “*Confederate Memorial*,” Arlington National Cemetery Official Website, U.S. Army, August 2025, <https://www.arlingtoncemetery.mil/Explore/Monuments-and-Memorials/Confederate-Memorial>.

⁴ “*Confederate Memorial*”

Jackson also described what happens when a monument's message no longer resonates with the society that built it. When a culture outgrows the ideals its monuments express, he wrote, they become "ruins"—objects emptied of living belief that invite reflection instead of worship.⁵ The *Confederate Memorial* has followed precisely this path. Once celebrated as a gesture of reconciliation, it now stands (or rather stood) as an artifact of racial mythmaking. Its dismantling in 2023 completed that transformation from monument to ruin: a structure stripped of honor, preserved only for study. At its dedication in 1914, President Woodrow Wilson praised the spirit of reunion. Yet the reunion envisioned at Arlington was a reconciliation between white Southerners and white Northerners, built on the exclusion of African Americans from national memory. Historians have noted that in the decade before the monument's unveiling, more than seven hundred people were lynched across the United States. The *Confederate Memorial* belonged to that same cultural moment, lending artistic respectability to white supremacy under the guise of peace.

Moses Jacob Ezekiel himself complicates this history. Born in 1844 to a Sephardic Jewish family in Richmond, he became the first Jewish cadet at Virginia Military Institute and fought for the Confederacy at the Battle of New Market. After the war, he studied sculpture in Europe and achieved international acclaim. In Rome, he produced neoclassical statues celebrating liberty, faith, and cultural harmony. He maintained that "None of us had ever fought for slavery,"⁶ a claim consistent with the Lost Cause's revisionist denial of slavery's centrality to the war. Art historian Samantha Baskind calls Ezekiel "a study in contradictions—a fervent American and yet an expatriate, a sculptor of religious liberty and yet an ardent memorializer of

⁵ Jackson, *Necessity for Ruins*, 65.

⁶ Samantha Baskind, "Moses Jacob Ezekiel, Confederate soldier and American Jewish sculptor | OUPblog," Oxford University Press blog, October 2017, <https://blog.oup.com/2017/10/jacob-ezekiel-sculptor/>.

the Lost Cause.”⁷ For Ezekiel, the Arlington commission was both an honor and a reconciliation of identities: Jewish, Southern, and artistic. He considered the *Confederate Memorial* the “crowning achievement” of his career and asked to be buried beside it.⁸ His artistic skill gives the work undeniable aesthetic power, but his ideological blindness ensured that its beauty served falsehood.

In recent years, debates over Confederate monuments have revived questions about how societies remember. When New Orleans removed its Confederate statues, Mayor Mitch Landrieu explained that “there is a difference between remembrance of history and reverence of it.”⁹ To remember, he said, is to teach; to revere is to perpetuate injustice. Landrieu condemned such monuments as celebrations of “a fictional, sanitized Confederacy—ignoring the death, ignoring the enslavement, ignoring the terror it actually stood for.”¹⁰ His distinction clarifies why Ezekiel’s memorial could not remain untouched: it transformed remembrance into reverence.

Some voices have urged caution, however. Writer Elliot Ackerman has argued that Confederate monuments in cemeteries and battlefields should remain as “areas of our complex past that should be left untouched.”¹¹ In his view, these spaces already function as historical documents, not civic shrines. According to this argument, the Arlington memorial, surrounded by Confederate graves, could serve an educational purpose if properly contextualized—with plaques, tours, or counter-monuments that expose its distortions. Indeed, before its removal, some preservationists proposed keeping it in place with added interpretation that would shift it

⁷ Baskind, “*Moses Jacob Ezekiel*”

⁸ Baskind, “*Moses Jacob Ezekiel*”

⁹ Mitch Landrieu, “*Address on the Removal of Confederate Monuments*,” (speech, New Orleans, LA, May 23, 2017), New York Times, <https://www.nytimes.com/2017/05/23/opinion/mitch-landrieus-speech-transcript.html>.

¹⁰ Landrieu, “*Removal of Confederate Monuments*”

¹¹ Elliot Ackerman, “*The Confederate Monuments We Shouldn’t Tear Down*,” The New York Times, July 7, 2020, <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/07/07/opinion/confederate-graves-arlington-cemetery.html>.

from a shrine to a classroom. This reasoning holds merit: destruction risks forgetting the power of art to shape ideology. Yet even Ackerman's nuanced stance falters in the case of Arlington. The cemetery is a national symbol of unity and sacrifice under one flag. To honor the Confederacy there is to blur the moral line between defenders of the nation and those who sought to dissolve it. As *The Atlantic* observed, the memorial elevated Confederates "in the nation's most sacred ground," effectively equating their cause with that of the Union.¹² In such a setting, recontextualization was not enough; relocation became necessary.

In 2021, Congress mandated that Confederate symbols be removed from all military property under the National Defense Authorization Act. The Department of Justice later confirmed that the Arlington memorial had to be dismantled "as required by Congress and implemented by the Secretary of Defense."¹³ In December 2023, the Army removed its bronze figures and placed them in storage, leaving only the granite base. The physical act of dismantling literalized Jackson's metaphor: the monument became a ruin, its absence more eloquent than its presence. Where once stood a grand allegory of the Lost Cause now lies an empty pedestal—an unintentional but powerful monument to accountability.

Critics of removal often claim that taking down monuments erases history. Yet, as Jackson reminds us, monuments are not history; they are interpretations of it. Their presence or absence does not change the record of the past but reshapes its meaning in public space. Landrieu posed a piercing question: "Why are there no prominent markers to the slaves, to the

¹² Clint Smith, "Arlington's Civil War Legacy Is Finally Laid to Rest," *The Atlantic*, December 23, 2023, <https://www.theatlantic.com/ideas/archive/2023/12/arlington-cemetery-confederate-monument/676965/>.

¹³ "Confederate Memorial must be Removed from Arlington National Cemetery" (press release, Washington, DC, April 17, 2024).

lynchings, to the auction blocks?”¹⁴ The selective commemoration of Confederate sacrifice already represents a profound erasure—the erasure of Black suffering. Removing Ezekiel’s sculpture corrects that imbalance rather than deepens it. Others warn that such removals divide the nation. But unity built on false equivalence is fragile. Genuine reconciliation depends on truth, not nostalgia. A nation that acknowledges the injustice of slavery and the propaganda of the Lost Cause strengthens its democratic foundation rather than weakens it.

Ezekiel’s *Confederate Memorial* demonstrates how art can transform ideology into beauty—and how that beauty can disguise injustice. Its polished bronze and classical forms rendered the Confederacy noble, while its inscriptions cast treason as virtue. Through Jackson’s lens, the memorial reveals itself as an interpretation of history so distant from truth that it collapsed under the weight of its own myth. Its removal in 2023 fulfilled Jackson’s prediction that discredited monuments become ruins, sites where new understanding can emerge. Preserved only as an artifact, Ezekiel’s work still speaks. It warns how easily artistic grandeur can lend moral authority to falsehood and how monuments shape the stories nations tell about themselves. In Arlington, where headstones mark those who fought for a united country, the absence of the *Confederate Memorial* now tells its own story—a reminder that public art, like memory itself, must evolve toward justice.

¹⁴ Landrieu, “*Removal of Confederate Monuments*”

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Confederate Memorial, Moses Jacob Ezekiel, Sculpture, 1914, Arlington National Cemetery.